Office apps crashing or freezing

Article KB0010058 | Owner: Application Support | Subcategory: Microsoft Office | Applies to: Windows 11 23H2/24H2 (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS 14/15 (MacBook Pro/Air), Microsoft 365 Apps for enterprise (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, OneNote)

Summary

This article guides users and service-desk agents through troubleshooting Microsoft Office applications that crash, freeze, fail to start, or show activation prompts. It covers common symptoms, likely causes, a self-help quick-repair and licence-refresh procedure, and the steps the Application Support team takes when the issue persists. Follow the verification steps to confirm the problem is resolved before closing the ticket.

Symptoms

- Excel or Word stops responding and displays "Not Responding" in the title bar
- Application closes unexpectedly with an error such as "Excel has stopped working" or "Word experienced a problem and needs to close"
- Office prompts to activate or sign in even though a valid licence is assigned
- Files open slowly or appear corrupted, showing "Unable to read file" or "The file is corrupted and cannot be opened"
- Overall sluggish performance, frequent hangs when switching worksheets or tabs

Common causes

- Corrupted Office installation or missing system files
- Faulty or incompatible COM add-ins (e.g., third-party PDF converters, analysis toolpak)
- Expired or stale licence token causing activation prompts
- Profile corruption in Outlook or Excel (e.g., damaged normal.dotm, XLSTART folder)
- Insufficient resources due to heavy workloads or concurrent memory-intensive processes
- Pending Windows updates that require a reboot after Patch Tuesday

Initial Checks

Before attempting repairs, verify basic conditions that often resolve the issue quickly. Ensure the device is connected to the corporate network (VPN or Wi-Fi ACME-Corp) so that Office can validate its licence. Confirm that no other Office instance is running in the background by checking Task Manager (Ctrl+Shift+Esc) and ending any WINWORD.EXE, EXCEL.EXE, or POWERPNT.EXE processes. Finally, ask the user to reproduce the problem with a new, blank document to determine whether the fault is file-specific or application-wide.

Self-Help Procedure

Follow these steps to perform a quick repair and refresh the Office licence. This resolves most crashes, freezes, and activation prompts without needing agent intervention. If the problem persists after completing the procedure, gather the details noted in the verification step and contact the Service Desk.

1. Close all Office applications. Right-click the Start button and select **Apps & features**. Locate **Microsoft 365 Apps for enterprise** (or **Office 2019/2021**) in the list, click **Modify**, then choose **Quick Repair** and press **Repair**. Wait for the process to finish (typically 5-10 minutes).
2. After the repair, open any Office app (e.g., Word). If prompted to sign in, enter your Acme Global corporate email address and complete MFA via Microsoft Authenticator or backup SMS. This refreshes the licence token.
3. If the app still crashes, disable add-ins: launch the problematic Office app, go to **File -> Options -> Add-Ins**. At the bottom, set **Manage:** to **COM Add-ins**, click **Go...**, uncheck all listed add-ins, and click **OK**. Restart the Office app and test. Re-enable add-ins one-by-one to isolate the faulty one.
4. Should the issue remain, reset the Office user profile: press Win+R, type %localappdata%\Microsoft\Office, and rename the folder corresponding to the version (e.g., 16.0) to 16.0_backup. Office will create a fresh profile on next launch. Note that this removes customised ribbon settings and recent-file lists.

Service Desk Procedure

When a ticket arrives with the above symptoms and the user has already attempted the self-help steps (or cannot

perform them), the Application Support agent follows this structured workflow. The goal is to isolate the root cause, apply a targeted fix, and confirm stability before closure.

1. Ask the user to confirm the exact error message or behavior and note whether it occurs with a specific file or with a blank document. Capture screenshots if possible.
2. Verify network connectivity and licence status: have the user open **File -> Account** in any Office app and confirm the product shows **Licensed Product** with their Acme Global email. If it shows **Unlicensed** or **Needs activation**, proceed to licence refresh.
3. Run the **Online Repair** option from **Apps & features -> Microsoft 365 Apps -> Modify -> Online Repair** (takes 10-20 minutes). This replaces corrupted local files while preserving user data.
4. If Online Repair does not help, collect logs: navigate to %temp%\Office16\SetupLogs and copy the most recent *.log* file. Also run **msinfo32** and export the system summary for hardware context.
5. Based on logs, identify failing add-ins or corrupted COM components. Disable suspect add-ins via Group Policy or via the registry (HKCU\Software\Microsoft\Office\<App>\Addins) and test again.
6. If the problem is isolated to a single document, attempt recovery: open Excel, choose **File -> Open -> Browse**, select the file, click the arrow next to the Open button, and choose **Open and Repair**. Repeat for Word if needed.
7. After applying the fix, ask the user to reproduce the original scenario (open the problematic file, work for 5-10 minutes, switch between sheets/tabs). Confirm that the application remains responsive and no error messages appear.

Verification and Closure

Once the issue appears resolved, both the user and the agent should perform a brief validation to ensure the fix is durable. Document the outcome in the ticket and provide the user with preventive tips to reduce recurrence.

1. Have the user open the previously problematic file and perform a typical workload (e.g., enter data, apply formulas, create a chart) for at least five minutes. Verify that the program does not hang or crash.
2. Check that the Office **Account** page still displays a valid licence and that MFA prompts are not repeatedly appearing.
3. If the user uses Outlook, confirm that sending/receiving mail works and that no add-in related errors appear in the application log.
4. Close the ticket with a resolution note summarising the steps taken (e.g., 'Performed Online Repair, disabled faulty XYZ add-in, verified stability'). Add the KB article reference (KB0010058) for future reference.

When to escalate

If the Office application continues to crash or freeze after completing the Service Desk Procedure (Online Repair, add-in isolation, and profile reset), escalate to the **Identity & Access Management** team for deeper licence/token investigation, or to the **Desktop Support** team for potential OS-level corruption (e.g., Windows system file damage, pending Patch Tuesday reboot required). Include in the escalation: the exact error messages, screenshots, Office version/build number, recent Windows update history, and the logs collected (%temp%\Office16\SetupLogs*.log and msinfo32 output).

Keywords: Office crashing, Excel not responding, Word activation prompt, Office quick repair, Online Repair, disable add-in, Office licence refresh, Office profile reset, file corrupted, Office slow performance, Microsoft 365 Apps, Acme Global IT Help